

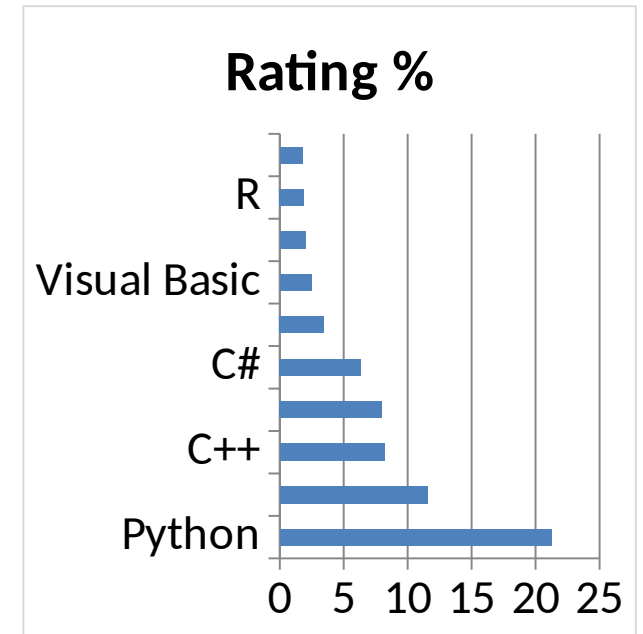
TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Data-forward analysis for software engineering leads and technology strategists

- TIOBE measures language popularity via search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites.
- It reflects discussion and demand signals (engineers, courses, vendors), not code volume or intrinsic language quality.
- March 2026 confirms TIOBE will continue using search-index methodology rather than LLM-derived assessments.

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Rank 2026	Rank 2025	Language	Rating	YoY
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%



- Top 4 share: 48.97% of index
- Python YoY: -2.59 pts
- C YoY: +2.02 pts (largest gain)

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Gainers (Rank Up)

Perl: 24 → 11 (+13)

R: 16 → 9 (+7)

Swift: 26 → 20 (+6)

Losers (Rank Down)

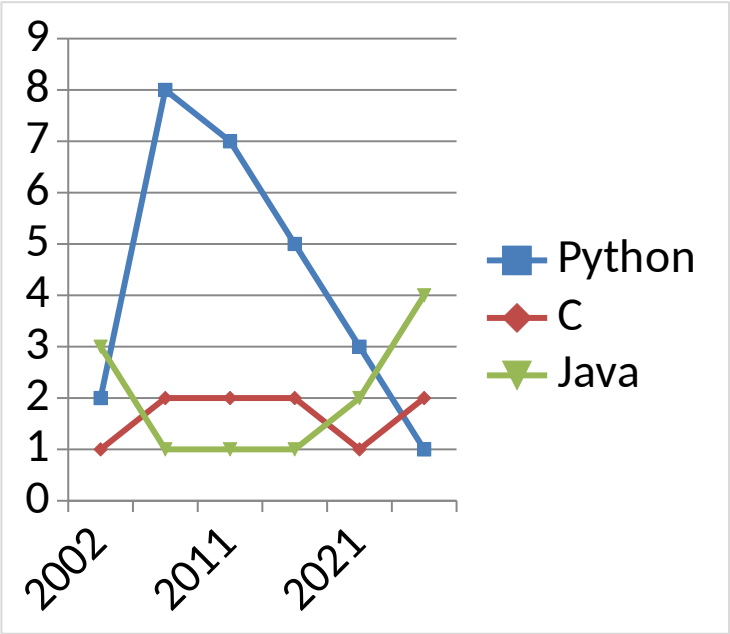
Go: 7 → 16 (-9)

C++: 2 → 3 (-1)

Java: 3 → 4 (-1)

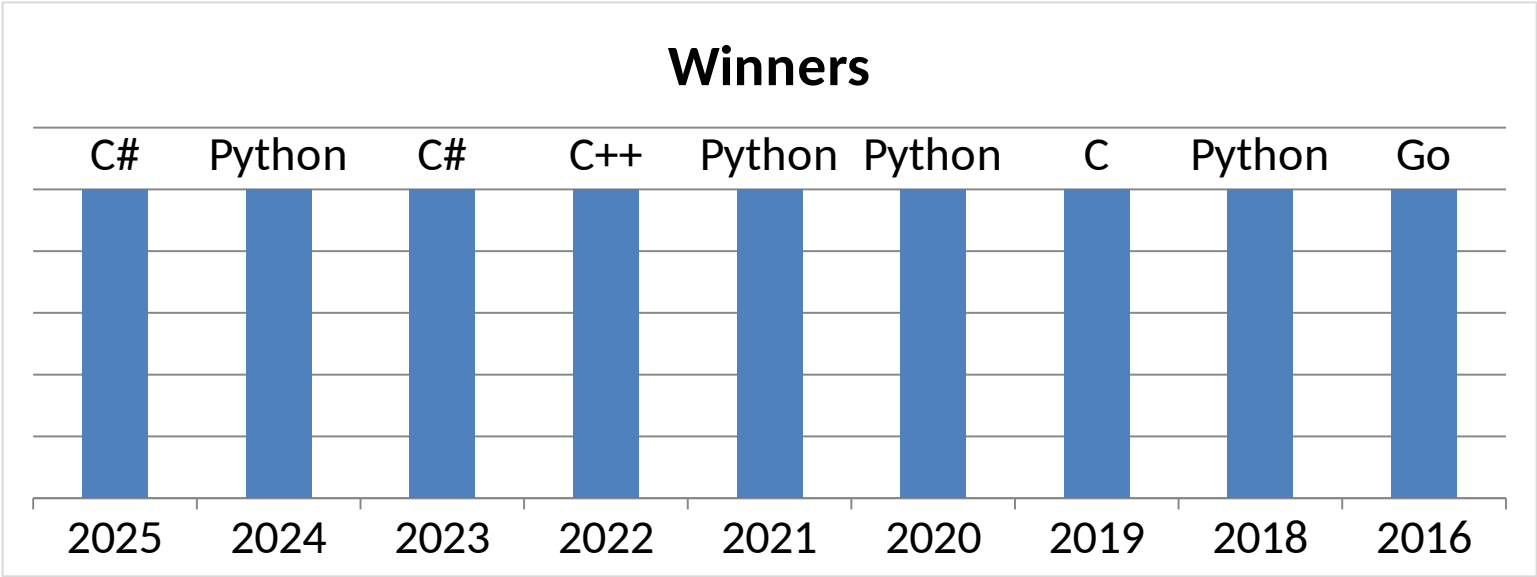
From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	-	-
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	-	-
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	-	-	-
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	-	-
Go	10	11	60	16	-	-	-	-	-
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2



- Python: unranked pre-1991 → #1 in 2026
- C: only language top-2 at all 9 points
- Java: #1 era to #4 today

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language



Key points

- Python total wins: 6 (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024)
- C# won 2023 and 2025
- Go won 2016 before current drop
- 2017 winner not available in source

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Findings

- Python remains #1 at 21.25% but is declining YoY (-2.59).
- C surged to #2 with +2.02, while C++ and Java slipped.
- Legacy rebound: Perl (+13 ranks), R (+7), Fortran still top 15.
- Go fell hardest (7→16, -1.49), signaling ecosystem pressure.
- Market concentration: top 4 languages = 48.97%.

Implications for strategy

- Balance portfolio: combine dominant and rising niche languages.
- Reassess language roadmaps annually using momentum signals.
- Align hiring/training spend to resilience + growth areas.
- Mitigate concentration risk by avoiding single-language lock-in.
- Track legacy-language demand in scientific and infra workloads.